FREE CHECKLIST FROM THE IMPACT PLATFORM

Making Policies Inclusive

The Inclusion Edit
Capacity. Capability. Change.

Fourteen tips for designing inclusive policies from scratch, or auditing one you already have, so it works for everyone it affects.

Checklist · About 20 minutes · Updated October 2026

HOW TO USE THIS

1. Choose one policy to review, or one you are about to write.
2. Work through the 14 tips. Tick each one the policy already meets.
3. Note what needs to change under any tip you cannot tick yet.
4. Finish with your three priority changes and who needs to agree them.

FILL IT IN ON SCREEN

Open this PDF in Adobe Acrobat Reader (free), Chrome or Edge to fill in and save your work. Previews inside email or on some phones may not let you type, so download it first.

THE POLICY YOU ARE REVIEWING

Policy name

Policy owner

Review date

Design

Get the foundations right before you draft.

01 Start with the people the policy affects

Before drafting, consult employees from groups the policy is most likely to affect: through surveys, focus groups, or one-to-one conversations. Policies designed without input from affected people consistently produce unintended gaps.

☐ **Audit question:** Did the policy involve meaningful consultation with affected groups before drafting?

What needs to change

02 Conduct an equality impact assessment

Assess how the policy could affect people differently based on protected characteristics. Document the assessment and publish it alongside the policy so the reasoning is transparent.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Has a documented equality impact assessment been completed and published?

What needs to change

03 Write in plain language

Use short sentences, active voice, and everyday words. Aim for a reading age of 9 to 11 years. Avoid acronyms, legalese, and unexplained jargon. Plain language is not just a style preference: it is an access requirement.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Has the policy been reviewed against a plain language standard?

What needs to change

04 Use inclusive language throughout

Use gender-neutral terms, avoid ableist language, and do not conflate marital status with family structure. Review all examples and scenarios in the policy for assumptions about who the 'default' employee is.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Has the policy been reviewed for inclusive language and assumptions about the default employee?

What needs to change

Scope

Be clear about who it covers and how it flexes.

05 Define scope clearly and comprehensively

State explicitly who the policy applies to: employees, workers, contractors, volunteers, board members. Vague scope creates inconsistent application, which disproportionately affects those with less institutional power.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Does the policy explicitly state who it covers, including non-employee workers?

What needs to change

06 Address intersectionality explicitly

Policies that address one protected characteristic in isolation can inadvertently disadvantage people with intersecting identities. Consider how your policy operates for someone who holds multiple protected characteristics simultaneously.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Does the policy consider the experience of people with intersecting protected characteristics?

What needs to change

07 Build in flexibility by default

Where a policy sets a standard approach, also specify the process for requesting variations or adjustments. Do not force employees to navigate a separate process to ask for what the policy should have anticipated.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Does the policy include a clear process for requesting adjustments or exceptions?

What needs to change

Process

Remove room for bias in how it is applied.

08 Specify decision-making criteria

Vague policies delegate too much discretion to individual managers, which introduces bias. Define the criteria for any discretionary decisions within the policy and document how those criteria should be weighted.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Does the policy specify criteria for discretionary decisions rather than leaving them to managerial judgement?

What needs to change

09 Define accountability and escalation routes

Name who is responsible for implementing the policy, who employees can go to with questions or concerns, and what happens if the policy is not followed. Accountability must be specific: a named role, not a department.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Does the policy name specific accountable roles and a clear escalation route?

What needs to change

10 Make the policy accessible in multiple formats

Publish policies in accessible digital formats: screen-reader-friendly, with sufficient colour contrast and resizable text. Offer paper copies, easy-read versions, or translations where there is reasonable need.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Is the policy available in accessible digital formats, and are alternative formats offered where needed?

What needs to change

Review

Check it works in practice, not just on paper.

11 Set a review date at the point of publication

Every policy should carry a review date: typically one to three years from publication, or sooner if legislation changes. A policy without a review date is a policy without accountability.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Does the policy carry a review date and a named owner responsible for initiating the review?

What needs to change

12 Track usage and outcomes by protected characteristic

Monitor who is using the policy and what outcomes they experience. Collect data disaggregated by protected characteristic so you can identify whether the policy is working equitably in practice, not just on paper.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Is there a mechanism to track policy usage and outcomes disaggregated by protected characteristic?

What needs to change

13 Gather feedback from those who use it

Build in a feedback mechanism so employees can report where the policy worked, where it fell short, and what they needed that was not there. Treat this feedback as evidence that informs the next version.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Does the policy include a mechanism for employees to give feedback on their experience of using it?

What needs to change

14 Compare against sector benchmarks and legal developments

At review, check the policy against current legislation, ACAS guidance, and sector benchmarks. Best practice evolves: a policy that was excellent three years ago may now fall below the standard employees and regulators expect.

- [ ] **Audit question:** Has the policy been reviewed against current legislation, ACAS guidance, and sector best practice?

What needs to change

YOUR SUMMARY

Criteria met: _____ out of 14

My three priority changes

Who needs to agree them, and by when?

Why inclusive policy design matters

Policies are the operating system of an organisation. They set the conditions under which people work, are evaluated, progress, and are supported. When policies are poorly designed, or designed without considering the full range of people they affect, the gaps they create are not neutral: they consistently disadvantage those who are already under-represented or vulnerable.

Inclusive policy design is not about adding an EDI paragraph to the end of an existing document. It is about beginning with the question: who does this policy affect, and how might it affect them differently? That question, asked genuinely and early, transforms the design process. It surfaces assumptions that would otherwise remain invisible and produces policies that work in practice, not just in principle.

This checklist is particularly useful for reviewing existing policies: those written before inclusive design principles were widely adopted, or not reviewed since the organisation's workforce or the legislative landscape changed. A policy audit is not a criticism of the people who wrote the original: it is a recognition that organisations and societies develop, and that the documents that govern working life need to keep pace.

Tip 14 refers to ACAS, the UK's workplace advisory service. Outside the UK, use your local equivalent and current employment law. This resource is not legal advice.

FROM THE IMPACT PLATFORM

You are not meant to carry this on your own.

This resource is one of more than 40 practical tools in the Impact Platform. Members also get:

- The interactive version of this resource, which saves your progress
- More than 40 practical tools, plus learning modules and evidence you can take to your leaders
- Inclusion AI tools and expert support as your membership grows

Start Your Membership | Book a Free Inclusion Call

Free to use and share inside your organisation with credit to The Inclusion Edit. info@theinclusionedit.com